Newsletter: July 2026

Hello River Champions! This edition of the newsletter is brought to you by Safina, our student group lead, and covers recent training and outreach initiatives. We break down Urban Riverfly 'trigger levels' at some sites that the Environment Agency have looked into (something that was touched on in the June newsletter).

Training Sessions:

Thank you to everyone who joined the recent training session, where the Packington River Blythe angling group and Blythe Angling and Conservation Society - our newest River Champions groups!

Our next training session is at Cannon Hill on the 21st July, please feel free to email **birminghamriverchampions@gmail.com** for further information.





Recent outreach

On the 13th June, the UoB River Champions group was invited to the Lark in the Park with the Manor Farm Park group. It was a great opportunity to speak to members of the public about water quality testing and invertebrate sampling. The response was outstanding!



Additionally, the student group partnered with the university's Commuter Society for the 26th-27th June open days. Together, they are promoting river sampling as a fun community-building activity for students living at home.

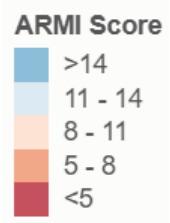
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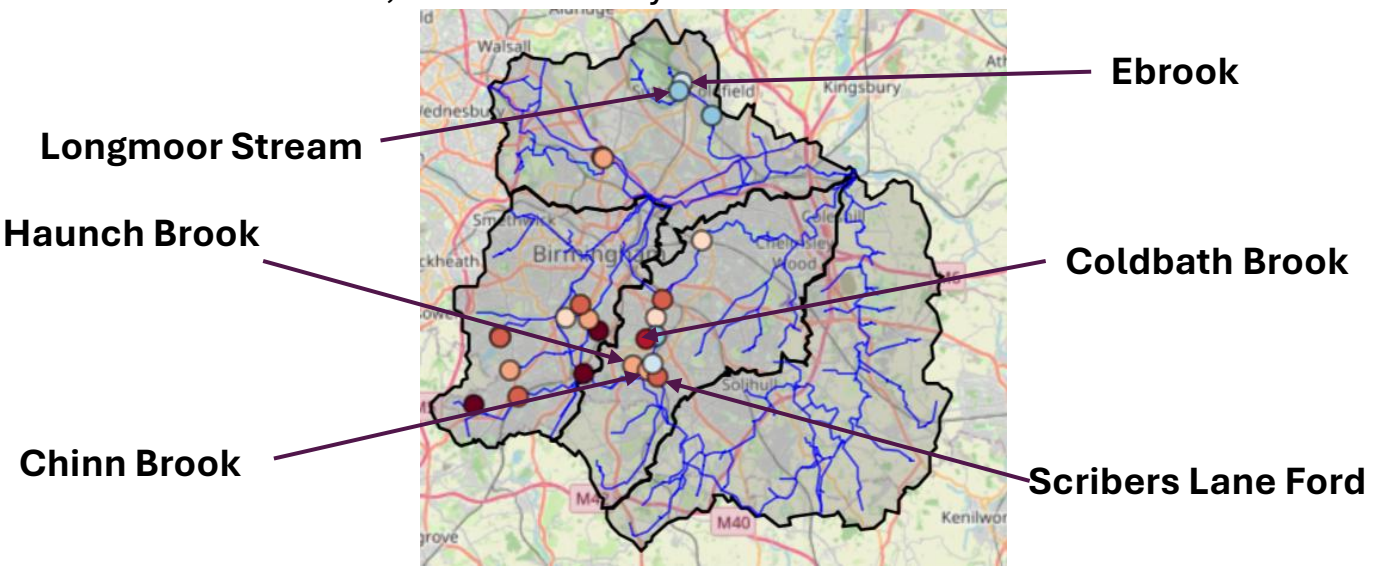
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Trigger levels

ARMI scores show the health of a river based on the invertebrates found. In general terms:
Higher scores = healthier water and more sensitive species.
Lower scores = possible stress, disturbance, or pollution.

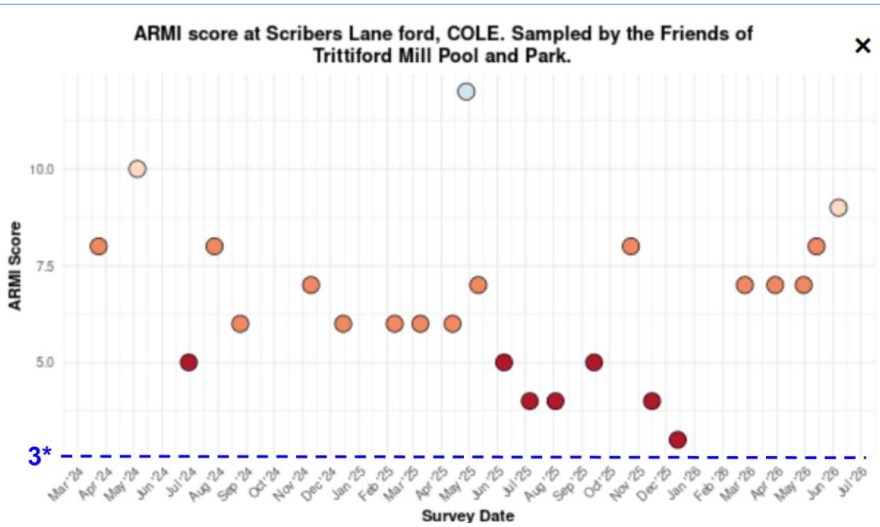


Trigger levels are ARMI score thresholds set by the Environment Agency (EA). If a site breaches its trigger level twice conescutively, it can flag issues worth looking into. The EA has now set trigger levels for several Birmingham sites with consistent data, which we present below along with their insights - these reflect the available evidence, not necessarily unmonitored issues.



Scribers Lane ford, River Cole

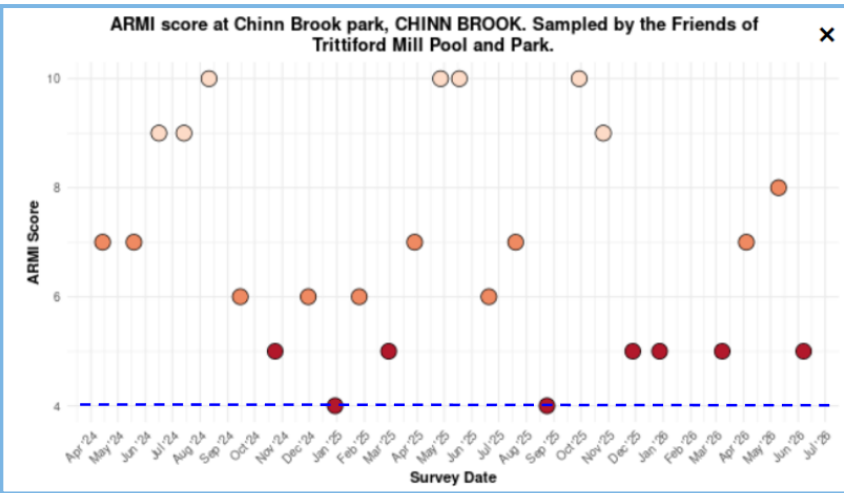
A trigger level of 3 has been set for now, which will be reviewed after a year to determine if it is too low. The site has a few historic contamination incidents, including one significant sewage event.



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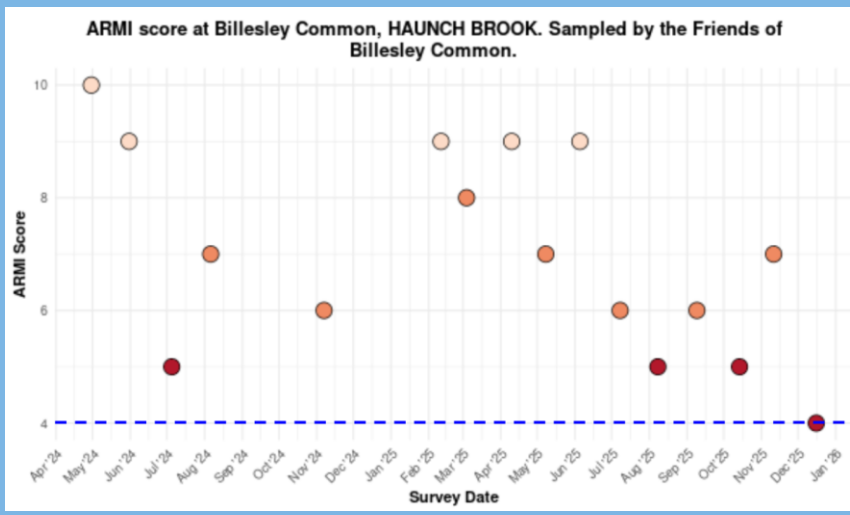


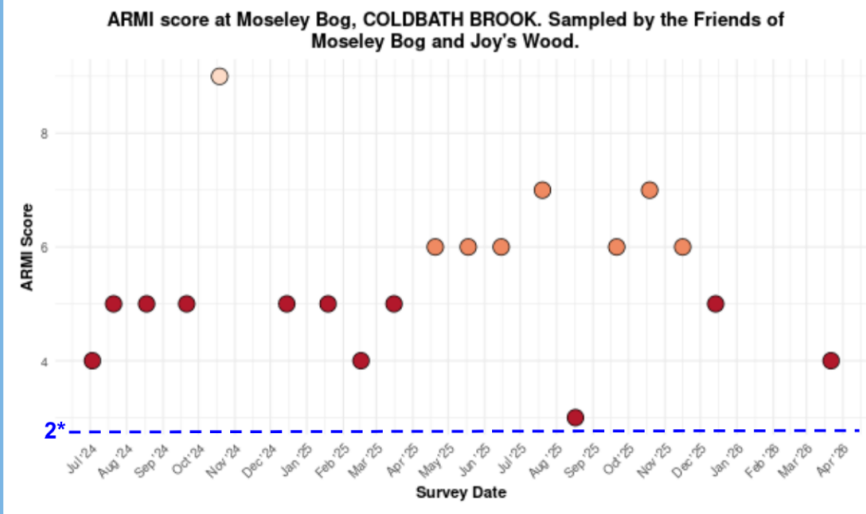
Chinn Brook (trib of R.Cole)

A trigger level of 3 has been set, with the option to raise it to 4 as more data builds. The brook has very few recorded incidents with only one in the last decade. As a tributary of the Cole, it's a useful site for understanding what flows into the main river.

Haunch Brook (trib. of Chinn Brook to the Cole)

A trigger level of 4 for now. The site sits in parkland with less sewage infrastructure than other Cole-adjacent sites. The site has only minor historic incidents near its source. The EA may not commit in-depth responses here, but desktop indications may be provided.





Coldbath Brook (trib. of the Cole past Moseley Bog)

A trigger level of 2 has been set provisionally but may increase. The brook has only minor historic incidents, but helps understand inputs into the Cole. The EA may not commit in-depth responses, but may provide a desktop review.

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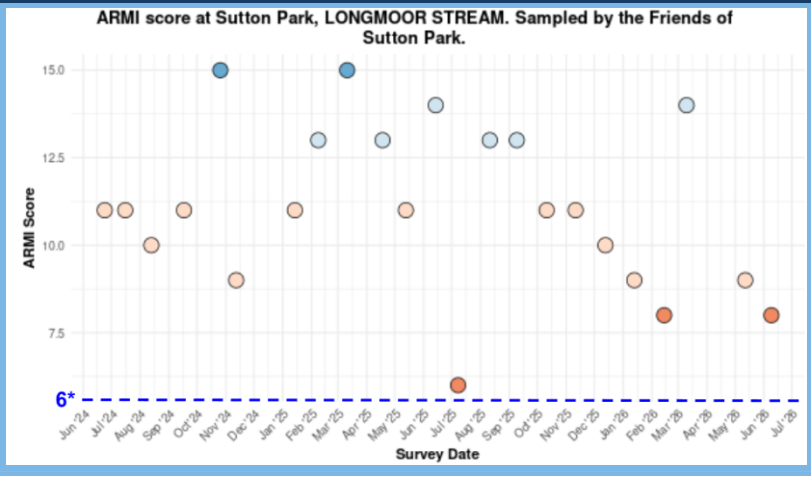
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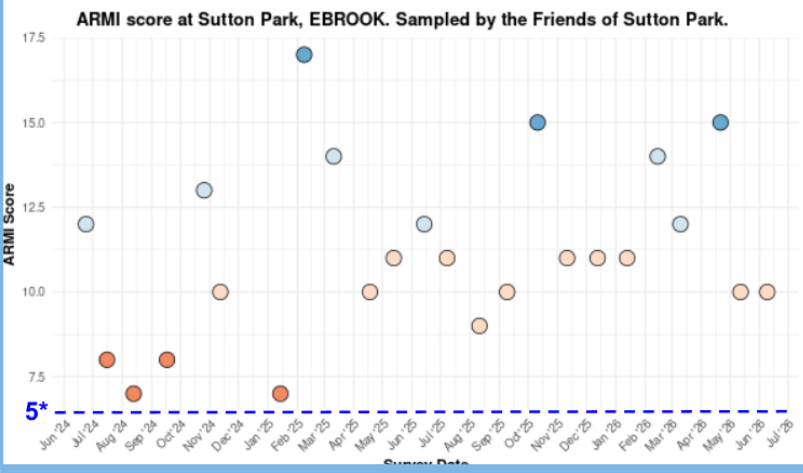
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Longmoor Stream (Tame catchment)

A trigger level of 6 has been set. This is a small Sutton Park stream with no major recorded issues, and any breach will be reviewed by the EA, with in-person site attendance not mandated.





Ebrook (Tame catchment)

A trigger level of 5 has been set.

This stream has no significant incident history and limited infrastructure nearby. It offers useful insight into the wider Plants Brook/Tame catchment. Breaches may be investigated remotely by the EA.

Summary

Thanks to all our volunteers for collecting Riverfly data across Birmingham's rivers! The trigger levels shared here are based on ***your*** records so far, and they'll continue to evolve as more data comes in. These 6 sites have been selected for now, and we'll continue working with the EA to set with more data. Together these sites show how differently Birmingham rivers behave:

- **Sutton Park Streams (Longmoor Stream and Ebrook):** Maintain higher, steadier ARMI scores due to minimal infrastructure and protected parkland environments.
- **River Cole Tributaries:** Show lower, more volatile scores that reflect everyday urban impacts, runoff, and historic sewage infrastructure stress.

Moving forward, if a site breaches its threshold twice in a row, it gives us a direct mechanism to flag the issue to the EA for investigation.

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